

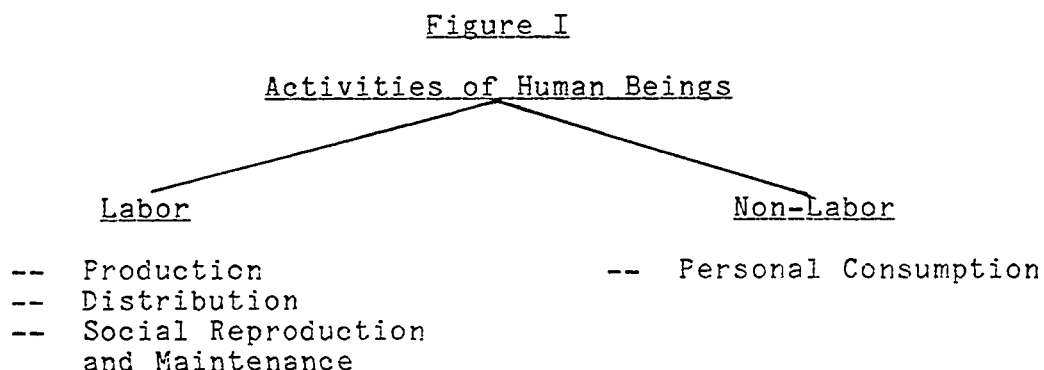
production for exchange, the objects of social use are transferred from one person to another through a set of activities in the sphere of distribution. Clearly, the activities of distribution are not necessary where no production exists for exchange. This latter case historically existed only in primitive communist societies where the dominant form of production was that undertaken for personal use. In the other pre-capitalist forms of societies, there was a production of values (production for exchange) which required distribution activities through which transfer of possession of objects of use-values (and values) could take place. Within capitalist society, on the other hand, production is not only for exchange but also for capital accumulation. In other words, besides small-scale, negligible production of use-values and values, the dominant form of production is the production of surplus-values which necessitates a complex set of distributive activities. Distribution activities all involve labor activities as well.³ This is also true for activities related to the social reproduction and maintenance of the society. Such activities have been an inevitable part of all class societies and obviously involve labor activity. Table II summarizes the activities of distribution and of social reproduction and maintenance throughout the historical stages of human societies.

Table II

Historical Stages of Human Societies	Nature of Distribution Activities & Social Re- production & Maintenance Activities
I. Primitive Communism	-- <u>Distributions</u>: There is no considerable distribution activity since there is no production for exchange. -- <u>Social Reproduction and Maintenance</u>: There is no such activity either since this is a classless and primitive society where "social life" is conflict-free and able to reproduce itself.
II. Pre-Capitalist	-- <u>Distribution</u>: There is a distribution of values. Commodities produced for exchange are distributed either by producers themselves or via merchants. -- <u>Social Reproduction and Maintenance</u>: Reproduction of social relations and their maintenance require institutions such as king, lord, emperor, army, legal system, etc.
III. Capitalist Society	-- <u>Distribution</u>: Value distribution, i.e., the distribution of commodities produced and sold by producers (family farming, artisans, etc.) -- <u>Surplus-value distribution</u>: The dominant and complex form of distribution -- <u>Social Reproduction and Maintenance</u>: Army, state, mass transportation, health, education, administration activities, etc.

The basic set of activities so far covered -- production, distribution and social reproduction and maintenance -- not only have common features within themselves over various historical stages of human societies but also have something in common among themselves which is the fact that all are labor activities.

The only set of activities involving no labor in the proper sense is personal consumption which is reproductive of members of society, but is neither production nor distribution nor social reproduction of the social order. Consequently, as a first step in defining PL as such, it would be useful to classify these basic human activities as labor and non-labor activities. Figure I represents such a classification.



As a second step in defining PL, we must focus on activities under the heading of labor. The division of human activities into labor and non-labor clearly does not give sufficient ground to define PL which must result in the creation of new wealth.⁴ This latter condition is obviously not satisfied by the activities

of distribution and of social reproduction and maintenance; they are non-production activities which require an involvement of human labor. However, this elimination process leads us only to define a set, "productive labor in general" is only a subset. In this sense, the historical specificity of the concept of PL should be emphasized.⁵ Consequently, the proper definition of PL must cover a set of activities within capitalist society which leads to the production of - surplus value from the "standpoint of capital". This definition can also be interpreted as a criterion for the identification of PL (hence UPL) within capitalist society. Labor which satisfies the following two conditions should be termed as productive labor: a) it must be exchanged with capital and thus satisfy the condition of being within the capitalist relations, b) it must produce surplus-value for the capitalist. Both these conditions clearly indicate the historical specificity of the concept.

In the next section, I shall exemplify the above criteria by referring to Marx's own writings on this issue and on the writings of other 19th century economists, particularly Adam Smith.

A.3 Marx on PUPL: the Debated Issues

In this section, I shall proceed as follows: First I want to emphasize the way in which Marx himself has

dealt with the issue. In this context, I will initially mention some errors that are common in evaluating Marx's writings; then I will present Marx's own formulation of the distinction between PUPL. Secondly, I will discuss some misconceptions and failures in dealing with that distinction in the context of Marx's own evaluations of other contributors into this theoretical domain.

Through that exposition it will be seen that various formulations, whose theoretical origins and failures are specifically underlined by Marx, are actually the original versions of the so-called 'original contributions' which have been recently presented in the debate on PUPL.

Prior to a review of how Marx defined PUPL, it would be useful to touch upon two factors which are usually unrecognized in theoretical works based on Marx, and, in turn, generally become a source of conceptual confusions. The first one is the failure of seeing Marx's work as theoretical product of a continuous process with a higher level of theoretical maturity at each stage of this process. Although manifestations of that failure can be observed in different forms in different contexts, for my present purpose I will only point out the one most widely shared; that is, picking up various definitions of PUPL developed by Marx in the course of a period of more than 25 years and, instead of capturing the evolution of these various definitions,

trying to demonstrate contradictions between them.⁶ Hence, basing themselves on such so-called contradictions, they either reject the Marxist framework or modernize it or in some cases manage to do both simultaneously! The other factor is the mistake of perceiving Marx's published and unpublished works, most of which were not written with a view to publication but rather for self-clarification purposes, without any distinction in terms of their relative significance for Marx's theoretical totality. That particular failure at times goes so far as to consider certain views, concepts, etc., written by Marx exclusively for self-clarification as almost absolute truths.⁷ One manifestation of this error is insufficient attention paid to the content of some concepts which are particularly relevant to the present discussion, and to the question of whether they were developed in finished works or presented in unfinished and unpublished works so that emphasis can be placed on them accordingly.⁸ This failure is the basis of many ongoing conceptual unclarities. There should not be any doubt that Marx himself defined PUPL within the context of circuits of capital and of revenue for historically specific society, namely capitalist society. Regardless of whether it is capitalists, any society must, in order to reproduce itself, carry out numerous production activities which themselves correspond to a certain level of

technological and organizational development of productive forces. An interpretation of PUPL distinction within a general and a historical framework, which classifies all laborers engaged in production activities in a pre-capitalist societies as productive laborers, has nothing to do with the definition of PL that Marx developed specifically in relation to the capitalist mode of production in order to explain the functioning of this particular form of society.

Let us look at this issue more closely. When the writings of Marx on PUPL are carefully studied, it is easily recognizable that the circuits of capital and of revenue (and related to these, relations of exchange and capital) play a central role. In the M-C phase of M-C ... P ... C'-M', which is itself the most general representation of the capitalist reproduction of material conditions, labor-power as a part of C is exchanged with a part of M (exchange with capital), then in the course of the production process it reproduces not only necessary values to reproduce itself but also a surplus-value.⁹ That characteristic of labor, the quality of producing surplus-value, leads Marx to define those activities as productive activities of labor, and labor as productive labor. That PL, to use Marx's phrase, "objectifies itself directly during the labor process as a fluid quantum of value." (Marx, 1973, p. 1040). A

few pages later in the Resultat, Marx recapitulates his position in the following way:

"Productive labor is exchanged directly for money as capital, i.e. for money which is intrinsically capital, which is destined to function as capital. Thus productive labor is labor which for the worker only reproduces the value of his labor-power as determined beforehand, while as a value-creating activity it valorizes capital and confronts the worker with the values so created and transformed into capital. The specific relationship between objectified and living labor that converts the former into capital also the latter into productive labor." (Marx, 1976, p. 1043)

In this general framework of PUPL, it is conceivable to interpret other specific definitions of PUPL in Marx. He presents the definition of PL as an element of the general circuit of capital just after the beginning of a section in the Resultat subtitled 'Productive and Un-productive Labor'.

"Since the immediate purpose and the authentic product of capitalist production is surplus-value, labor is only productive, and an exponent of labor-power is only a productive worker, if it or he creates surplus-value directly, i.e. the only productive labor is that which is directly consumed in the course of production for the valorization of capital." (Marx, 1976, p. 1038)

And in the same context, he also defines UPL in the following manner:

"Whenever labor is purchased to be consumed as a use-value, as a service and not to replace the value of variable capital with its own vitality and be incorporated into the capitalist process

of production - whenever that happens, labor is not productive and the wage-laborer is no productive worker. His work is consumed for its use-value, not as creating exchange-value; it is consumed unproductively, not productively. Hence the capitalist does not encounter it in his role of capitalist, a representative of capital. The money that he pays for it is revenue, not capital. Its consumption is to be formulated not as M-C-M, but C-M-C (the last being the labor or service itself). The money functions here only as a means of circulation, not as capital."¹⁰ (Marx, 1976, p. 1041)

The previous quotations make very clear that if a labor expenditure is paid out of revenue then such labor activity must be considered as UPL.¹¹ On the other hand, a similar reasoning does not guarantee that when a labor expenditure is paid out of capital it always becomes PL. Being exchanged with capital is only one of two necessary conditions, of which the other is the fact that labor engages in the production of surplus-value.

As demonstrated above, Marx defined productive labor as "value-creating" (Marx, 1976, p. 1038) and "directly surplus-value" - creating (Marx, 1976, p. 1038) labor, and unproductive labor as labor remunerated directly or indirectly out of revenue. And again in this sense, i.e., in relation to the general circuit of capital, he emphasizes that "these definitions are therefore ... derived ... from the definite social form and the social relations of production within which the labor is realized." (Marx, 1963, p. 157). Like Marx's other ideas, all his views concerning PUPL must be understood as a product of a long intellectual process

in which he critically appropriated the preceding contributions on the subject. Accordingly, a look at Marx's evaluation of prior writings on PUPL will serve to identify the unique characteristics of Marx's own definitions.¹²

In presenting Marx's assessment of these earlier contributions (especially Smith's), I shall focus on those questions that are particularly relevant for contemporary discussions of PUPL. This choice also helps to see how far back in time many of the still-debated issue go, and to what degree they were anticipated by Marx. First, in discussing Smith's definitions of PUPL, the significance of the distinction between production labor in general and productive-labor in capitalism will be reemphasized. In relation to this discussion, the relationship between productive labor and the intrinsic qualities of labor will be clarified. Then the issues of materiality, necessity, activity/individual distinction and domestic labor will be briefly analyzed.

In classical economics, the distinction between PUPL was initially developed by Adam Smith and then adopted by David Ricardo and Thomas Malthus with practically no alteration.¹³ It is widely known that there are two easily distinguishable definitions of PUPL in Smith's work.¹⁴ The first one, quoted below, puts a